

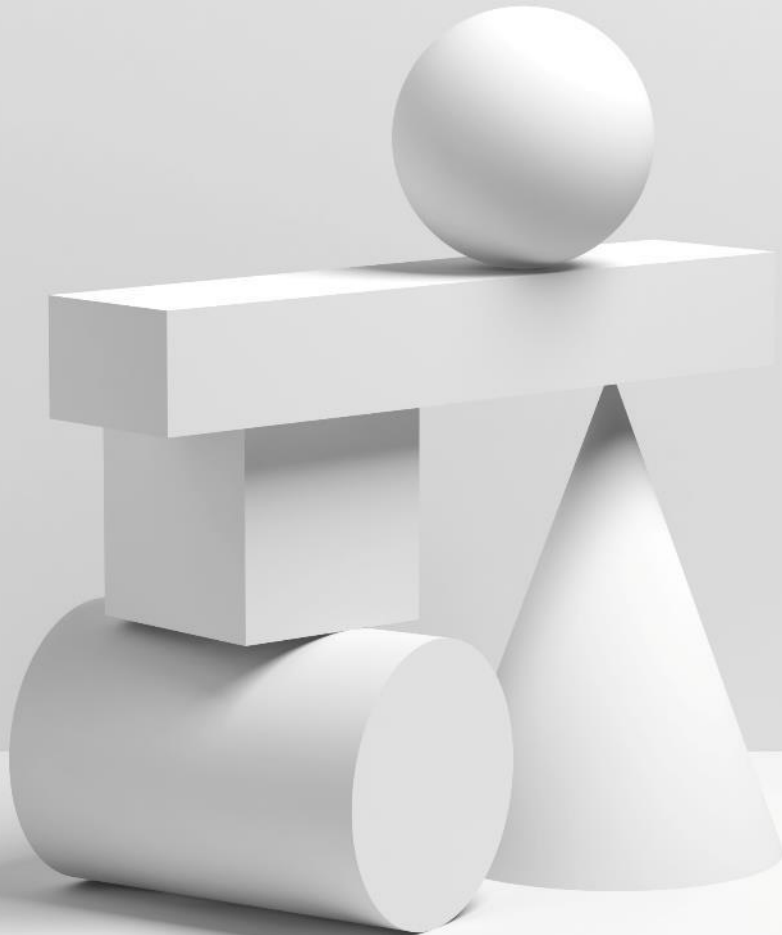
Presented by: Justin Morrow

Course CSD380: Module 8.2

Date: 07/18/26

DEVOPS: IMPLEMENTING A JUST CULTURE

FOR ORGANIZATIONS STRUGGLING TO OVERCOME A BLAME CULTURE AND SHIFT TOWARDS A SAFE ENVIRONMENTAL FOR SHARING BEST PRACTICES, AND CONTINUOUS FEEDBACK.



UNDERSTANDING JUST CULTURE

The Operational Balance

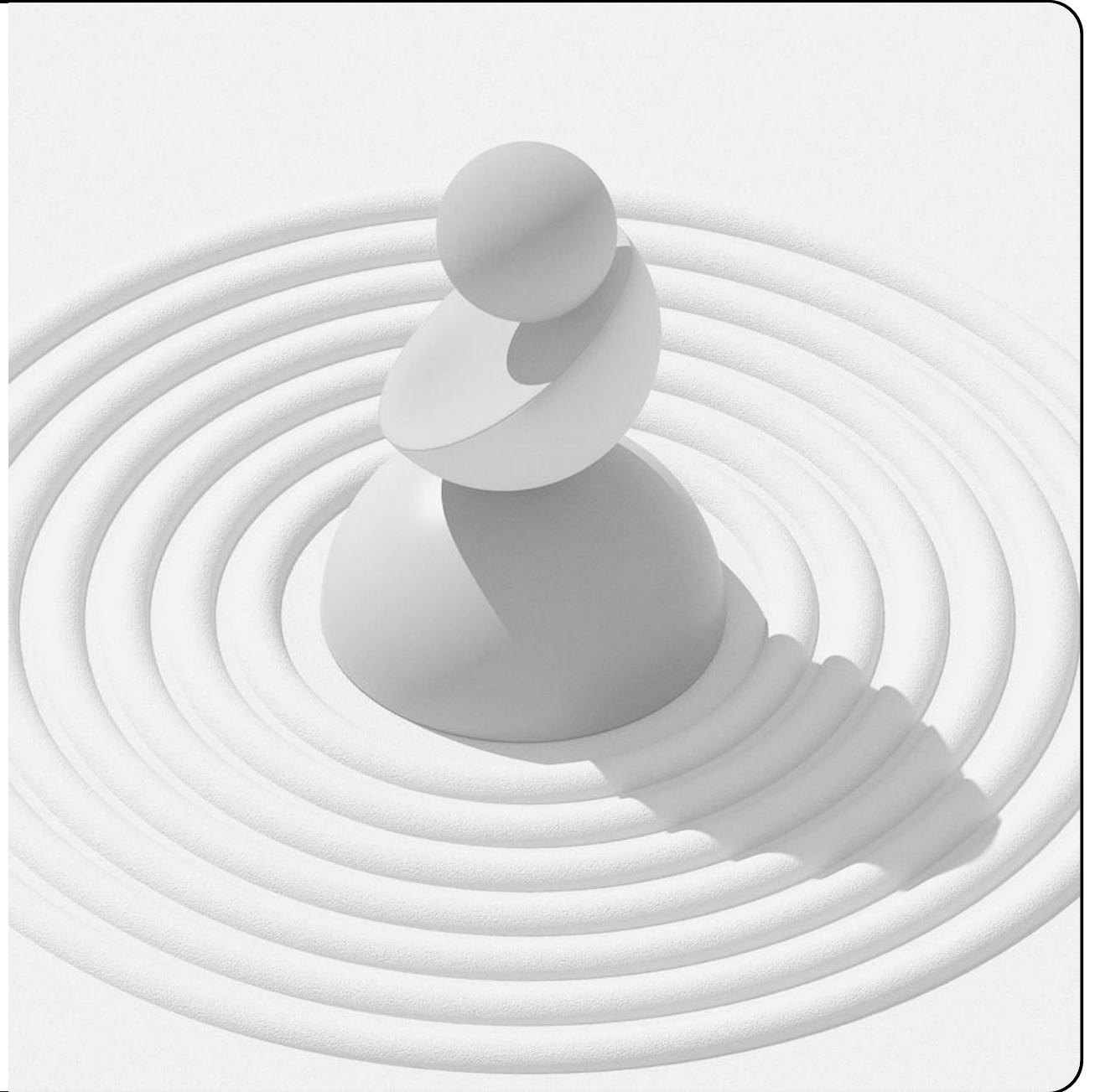
In network and software operations, a "Just Culture" isn't about avoiding accountability; it's about moving away from the "who" and looking at the "why." It recognizes that failures are usually systemic issues, not just human error. When we shift the focus from blaming the individual to examining the operational environment, like tooling gaps or configuration complexity, we can build more reliable systems without creating unnecessary bottlenecks or a culture of fear.

Why it Matters

These principles are now spilling over into other high-consequence industries. By creating an environment where it is safe to report near-misses, we can develop stronger feedback loops. Some mistakes—especially blatant or intentional ones—still require formal discipline, but the primary goal is to improve the process, not punish the person.

BARRIER 1: FEAR & BLAME

- The traditional name, blame and shame mentality slows down innovation due to engineers not willing to take calculated risks to find new solutions to problems.
- Engineers won't report incidents or failures that could be resolved with system enhancements or better guardrails put in place.
- Hiding systematic issues for fear of punishment can hidden major issues that result in system outages.



BARRIER 2: LEADERSHIP OBSTACLES

Punitive/Disciplinary Management

Leadership styles of command-and-control often default to blame when pressure rises, rather than coaching the team to improve the system.

Lack of Understanding or Training

Modern systems utilize telemetry dashboards for alarming and performance measurements. A leadership barrier can be a person defaulting to saying “No” to stop risks instead of searching for ways to systematically mitigate risks by utilizing or improving the tools.



BARRIER 3: ACCOUNTABILITY CHALLENGES

A **Fear Culture** is created when everyone stops reporting mistakes for **fear of being punished**. This culture causes the organization to **lose visibility** that otherwise could be used to **fix broken processes** or **human oversight**

CATEGORY	SITUATIONAL EXAMPLES	JUST CULTURE SOLUTION
Human Error	Mistakes happen when people are tired, over-worked, stressed, tired, etc. a person can enter a wrong command or miss a configuration step.	Instead of punishing the person, we should look at the process and fix the pipeline by adding input validation or automating configurations when possible.
At-Risk Behavior	This happens when engineers knowingly take shortcuts or bypass steps due to being under pressure to make deadlines.	Look to fix the broken process or operational pressure so the engineer isn't pressured to take shortcuts.
Reckless Behavior	This situation is often rare and happens when the engineer intentionally violates standards and bypasses security guardrails knowing the end results.	Reckless behavior requires individual accountability and discipline to maintain the integrity of the system or network.

A **Just Culture** puts the blame on the system for Human Errors, while only putting the blame on the individual for Reckless Behavior.

BUILDING RESILIENCY

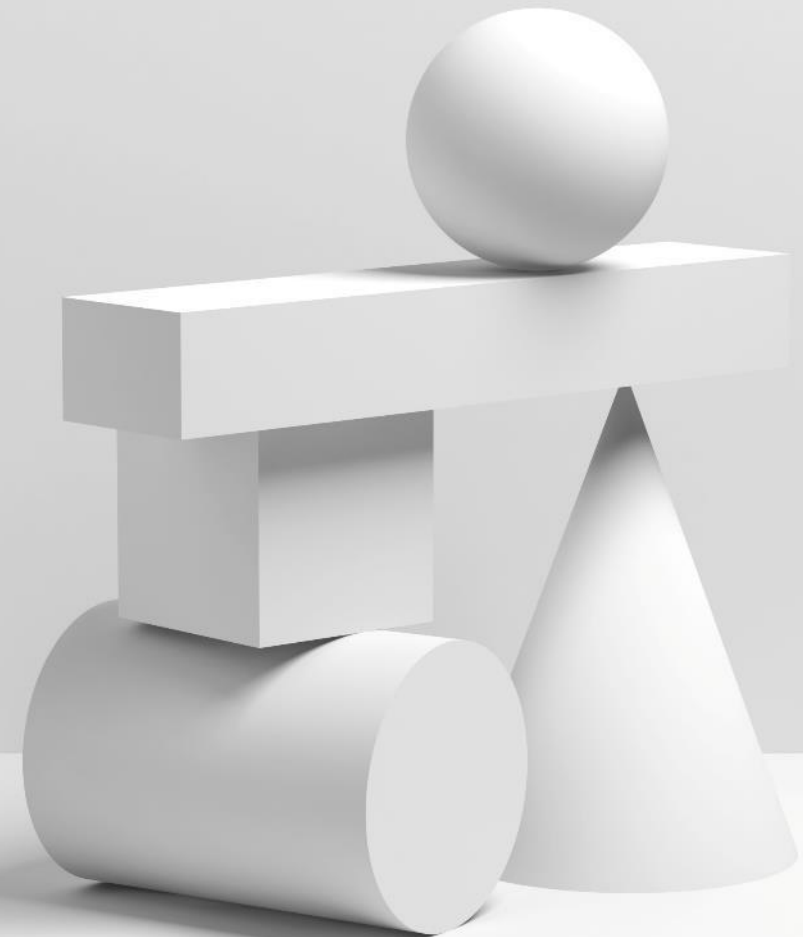
- Move the focus from “Who caused this?” to “What condition allowed this to happen?”
- Integrate telemetry and automated testing into the pipeline to improve visibility and catch issues before production. Improve reliability with quality controls throughout the pipeline rather than manual reviews.

EMBRACING FAILURE

“When mistakes are treated with blame, it signals lower levels of psychological safety, discouraging employees from sharing valuable learning experiences. However, a learning-oriented workplace that encourages openness, and sees failure as part of growth, ultimately driving productivity, innovation, and adaptability.” – Amy C. Edmondson

STRATEGIES TO IMPROVE

- **Build an Environment of Trust**
 - Encourage engineers to report mistakes without constant fear of punishment.
- **Automation over Manual Repetition**
 - Replace manual and repetitive tasks with automation scripting when possible and utilize security scans and monitoring telemetry.
- **Post-Mortems**
 - Focus on system and procedural gaps rather than human faults. Encourage and provide feedback in a way that leads to innovative ways at improving systems and processes.



ONLINE RESOURCES

WEB SITES	ARTICLE TITLE AND LINK
Humanistic Systems	<u>Why Is It Just So Difficult? Barriers to 'Just Culture' in the Real World</u>
Trailhead	<u>Understand the Role of Culture and Resilience</u>
EKCO	<u>How to Introduce DevOps</u>
LinkedIn	<u>Transforming Blame Culture: The DevOps Silent Productivity Killer Anti-Pattern</u>
Patient Safety	<u>Promoting a Culture of Patient Safety: Using the Principles of Just Culture to Improve Transparency and Risk Reporting in the Hospital Setting</u>
The Encompass Group	<u>EMBRACING FAILURE: CULTIVATING A LEARNING CULTURE IN THE WORKPLACE</u>